

# Power Platform Component & Feature Catalog

---

A Reference Guide for Architectural Decisions & Licensing

July 2026

## Table of Contents

|                                            |    |
|--------------------------------------------|----|
| Table of Contents.....                     | 2  |
| Introduction .....                         | 3  |
| Power Apps (Application Experiences) ..... | 4  |
| Canvas Apps .....                          | 4  |
| Model-Driven Apps.....                     | 5  |
| Code Apps.....                             | 5  |
| Power Apps Component Framework (PCF) ..... | 6  |
| Power Automate .....                       | 6  |
| Cloud Flows.....                           | 6  |
| Desktop Flows (RPA).....                   | 7  |
| Process Advisor .....                      | 7  |
| Dataverse.....                             | 8  |
| Relational Data Store .....                | 8  |
| Business Logic & Rules .....               | 8  |
| Security Model.....                        | 9  |
| Integration & Dataflows .....              | 9  |
| Power Pages.....                           | 10 |
| Web Portals.....                           | 10 |
| Design Studio & Templates .....            | 10 |
| Microsoft Copilot Studio.....              | 11 |
| AI Orchestration Platform.....             | 11 |
| Agent Flows.....                           | 11 |
| Plugins (Tools) Integration .....          | 12 |
| Responsible AI Controls.....               | 12 |
| Connectors & AI Builder .....              | 13 |
| Connectors .....                           | 13 |
| AI Builder .....                           | 13 |
| Licensing Summary .....                    | 14 |
| Common Selection Trade-offs.....           | 14 |
| Architectural Guidance .....               | 15 |
| Decision Method.....                       | 16 |
| Scenario-Based Selection Examples.....     | 16 |

## Introduction

This catalog provides a comprehensive reference for Microsoft Power Platform components and features (excluding Power BI), covering their purpose, capabilities, and essential licensing considerations. Use this document during solution design to select the right building blocks for a given scenario and to plan for licensing needs upfront.

The Power Platform ecosystem includes Power Apps, Power Automate, Dataverse, Power Pages, and Microsoft Copilot Studio — each serving distinct purposes that, when combined, enable organizations to build sophisticated, end-to-end business solutions with minimal code.

### How to Use This Catalog

- Review the component descriptions to understand each platform's primary use cases.
- Check the licensing column in each table before committing to a design.
- Refer to the Licensing Summary table for a quick cross-component overview.
- Apply the Architectural Guidance notes when choosing between components with overlapping capabilities.

## Power Apps (Application Experiences)

Power Apps is Microsoft's application platform for building custom business applications across low-code and pro-code experiences. It provides multiple app types suited for different use cases, from highly customized maker-built interfaces to structured Dataverse applications and code-first web apps hosted within the Power Platform runtime.

### Canvas Apps

Canvas Apps offer a flexible, drag-and-drop design experience with pixel-perfect control over the user interface. They are ideal for scenarios requiring highly customized layouts or integration with multiple data sources simultaneously.

| Requirement                           | Preferred Component |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------|
| Internal task experience              | Canvas Apps         |
| Structured business process           | Model-Driven Apps   |
| Enterprise custom software experience | Code Apps           |
| External portal                       | Power Pages         |
| Conversational assistant              | Copilot Studio      |
| Embedded AI in a process              | AI Builder          |

| Attribute    | Details                                                                                                |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best For     | Highly customized user interfaces or multi-source data integration                                     |
| Design Model | Drag-and-drop canvas; developer controls every element's size and position                             |
| Data Sources | SharePoint, Excel, Dataverse, SQL, and 900+ connectors                                                 |
| Licensing    | Microsoft 365 for standard connectors; Power Apps Premium required for Dataverse or premium connectors |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Canvas Apps when the solution needs a tailored task experience, custom layout, mobile-friendly interaction, or aggregation across multiple data sources. Avoid Canvas Apps for anonymous or public access, complex enterprise systems of record, or scenarios where Dataverse security, views, forms, and process consistency should be inherited by design.

## Model-Driven Apps

Model-Driven Apps are data-centric applications built atop Microsoft Dataverse. The UI — including forms, views, and dashboards — is automatically generated from the underlying data model, making them ideal for process-focused solutions such as CRM systems.

| Attribute    | Details                                                                                   |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best For     | Scenarios focused on structured data and automated processes (e.g., CRM, case management) |
| Design Model | Standardized, responsive UI auto generated from Dataverse table schema                    |
| Data Sources | Microsoft Dataverse (required)                                                            |
| Licensing    | Power Apps Premium license required (Dataverse dependency)                                |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Model-Driven Apps when the solution is centered on structured Dataverse data, relationships, forms, views, business processes, and role-based security. Avoid Model-Driven Apps when the primary value is a highly bespoke screen layout or when the data model is simple enough that a full Dataverse-backed process application would add unnecessary complexity.

## Code Apps

Code Apps are pro-developer application experiences in Power Apps that allow teams to build custom web applications in a code-first IDE and run them in Power Platform. They support modern web frameworks such as React and Vue while retaining managed platform capabilities such as Microsoft Entra authentication, connector access, DLP policy enforcement, Conditional Access, hosting, and application lifecycle management.

| Attribute         | Details                                                                                               |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best For          | Complex enterprise applications requiring maximum UI, logic, and engineering control                  |
| Development Model | Code-first development using IDEs, source control, web frameworks, and standard engineering practices |
| User Experience   | Fully customized web application experience                                                           |

| Attribute    | Details                                                                                                                      |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Data Sources | Dataverse, Power Platform connectors, Azure SQL, SharePoint, APIs, and external services                                     |
| Licensing    | End users typically require Power Apps Premium; additional licensing depends on Dataverse, connectors, and services consumed |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Code Apps when the solution requires a fully bespoke user experience, advanced frontend frameworks, complex client-side logic, software engineering control, or a standalone web app that should still benefit from Power Platform authentication, connectors, governance, and ALM. Avoid Code Apps when requirements can be met with Canvas Apps or Model-Driven Apps, when maker-led ownership is expected, or when speed of delivery is more important than maximum control.

**Architecture impact:** Code Apps shift ownership toward software engineering practices: source control becomes the system of record, CI/CD pipelines and automated testing become more important, and delivery may require professional developer capacity. The trade-off is higher engineering effort in exchange for maximum UX, logic, and extensibility control.

## Power Apps Component Framework (PCF)

The Power Apps Component Framework (PCF) is a pro-developer feature that allows custom code components to be embedded within Canvas and Model-Driven Apps, extending capabilities beyond out-of-the-box controls.

| Attribute  | Details                                                                               |
|------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best For   | Extending app UI with custom controls (e.g., specialized charts, interactive maps)    |
| Technology | TypeScript / JavaScript; React supported                                              |
| Licensing  | Included with Power Apps — no additional license beyond the hosting app's requirement |

**Selection guidance:** Choose PCF when out-of-the-box controls cannot meet an important usability, visualization, or interaction requirement. Avoid PCF for cosmetic preferences alone, because custom components introduce code lifecycle, accessibility, testing, and support responsibilities.

## Power Automate

Power Automate is the workflow and process automation service within the Power Platform, enabling automated sequences across apps and services. It supports both cloud-based digital process automation and desktop-based robotic process automation (RPA).

### Cloud Flows

Cloud Flows are server-side automation flows that run in the cloud. They can be triggered automatically (event-driven), on a schedule, or on demand, and are the primary mechanism for integrating systems and orchestrating data between services.

| Trigger Type | Description                                                                  | Licensing                                              |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Automated    | Triggered by an event (e.g., new SharePoint item, Dataverse record change)   | M365 for standard; Premium plan for premium connectors |
| Scheduled    | Runs on a defined recurrence (e.g., nightly data sync)                       | M365 for standard; Premium plan for premium connectors |
| Instant      | Manually triggered by a user from an app, Teams, or mobile                   | M365 for standard; Premium plan for premium connectors |
| High-Volume  | Flows requiring very high frequency or large-scale processing across systems | Per-flow license recommended for predictable capacity  |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Cloud Flows for API-based integration, event-driven automation, scheduled jobs, approvals, and orchestration across cloud services. Avoid Cloud Flows for fragile UI automation when a stable connector, API, Dataverse event, or custom connector can be used instead.

### Desktop Flows (RPA)

Desktop Flows provide Robotic Process Automation (RPA) capabilities, operating on desktop UI and web applications. They are used to automate manual, repetitive tasks in legacy systems that do not expose APIs.

| Mode           | Description                                                            | Licensing                                                |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Attended RPA   | User is present and interacts with the bot during execution            | Per-user license with RPA capability                     |
| Unattended RPA | Bot runs autonomously without a user present (e.g., overnight batches) | Unattended RPA add-on (per bot, per machine concurrency) |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Desktop Flows only when the target system does not expose a reliable API or connector and UI automation is the practical option. Avoid RPA for high-volume or mission-critical integration when an API, database integration, or connector-based approach is available, because UI automation is more sensitive to interface changes and operational interruptions.

## Process Advisor

Process Advisor is a process mining and analysis feature embedded within Power Automate. It enables organizations to visualize existing processes, identify bottlenecks, and discover automation opportunities by recording and analyzing user actions.

| Attribute  | Details                                                                             |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Use Case   | Identify inefficiencies and automation opportunities in existing business processes |
| Capability | Task recording, process visualization, analytics dashboards, and mining reports     |
| Licensing  | Some process mining features are premium; may require per-user license or add-on    |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Process Advisor when the current process is poorly understood, manual effort is high, or automation opportunities need evidence before investment. Avoid using it as a substitute for process ownership, requirements validation, or operational redesign.

## Dataverse

Microsoft Dataverse (formerly Common Data Service) is the cloud data platform underlying the Power Platform. It provides secure, scalable storage with built-in business logic, a rich security model, and integration capabilities that serve as the backbone for enterprise-grade solutions.

## Relational Data Store

Dataverse provides secure storage for tables (entities) that support rich data types, relationships, and business rules. It is the recommended central database for business applications requiring relational data, business logic, and row-level security.

| Feature           | Details                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tables (Entities) | Standard, custom, and virtual tables; supports rich column types including lookups, choices, and files                                     |
| Relationships     | One-to-many, many-to-many, and hierarchical relationships with referential integrity                                                       |
| Licensing         | Included with Power Apps and Power Automate Premium plans; also with Dynamics 365. Limited 'Dataverse for Teams' version available on M365 |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Dataverse as the preferred data platform for enterprise applications requiring relational modeling, security roles, auditing, business rules, ALM, and durable ownership. Avoid using SharePoint lists as the default transactional store when the solution requires complex relationships, row-level security, high data volume, regulated data, or long-term product lifecycle management.

## Business Logic & Rules

Dataverse includes built-in mechanisms to enforce business processes at the data layer, ensuring data integrity and enabling server-side automation independent of the consuming application.

| Mechanism             | Description                                                                                    | Licensing                                                              |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Business Rules        | Declarative rules applied at the form or table level (e.g., required fields, field visibility) | Included with Dataverse                                                |
| Calculated Fields     | Auto-computed field values based on defined formulas                                           | Included with Dataverse                                                |
| Rollup Fields         | Aggregate values from related records                                                          | Included with Dataverse                                                |
| Plugins (Server-side) | Custom .NET assemblies triggered by data events for complex logic                              | Included with Dataverse; compute capacity monitored via request limits |
| Classic Workflows     | Legacy process automation at the data layer                                                    | Included with Dataverse (deprecated in favor of Power Automate)        |

## Security Model

Dataverse provides a comprehensive, layered security model that governs access at multiple granularities, enabling organizations to enforce strict data access segregation appropriate for enterprise deployments.

| Security Layer        | Description                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Role-Based Access     | Security roles define privileges (Create, Read, Update, Delete, Append, Share) per table                          |
| Record-Level Security | Row ownership and business unit hierarchy restrict which records users can access                                 |
| Column-Level Security | Restrict access to sensitive columns (e.g., salary, SSN) on a per-field basis                                     |
| Hierarchy Security    | Manager-subordinate hierarchy model for cascaded access control                                                   |
| Licensing Note        | The security model is inherent to Dataverse; every user interacting with Dataverse must be appropriately licensed |



## Integration & Dataflows

Dataverse provides rich integration capabilities through OData and SDK APIs, virtual tables for real-time external data access, and Power Query-based dataflows for scheduled ETL operations.

| Integration Type | Use Case                                                                                          | Licensing                                          |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| OData & SDK APIs | Programmatic CRUD access; used by Power Apps, Power Automate, and custom integrations             | Included with Dataverse license                    |
| Virtual Tables   | Surface external data (e.g., SQL, SharePoint) in Dataverse in real time without copying it        | Dataverse license + source system access required  |
| Dataflows (ETL)  | Power Query-based, scheduled bulk import from SQL, Excel, and other sources into Dataverse tables | Premium licensing if connecting to premium sources |

**Selection guidance:** Use virtual tables when users need near real-time access to external data without copying it into Dataverse. Use dataflows when data should be transformed and loaded on a schedule. Use APIs or SDK-based integration when transactional consistency, custom logic, or system-to-system orchestration is required.

## Power Pages

Power Pages (formerly Power Apps portals) enables organizations to build external-facing websites backed by Dataverse data. It is designed for scenarios where customers, partners, or the public need to interact with organizational data through a secure, branded web experience.

### Web Portals

Power Pages delivers template-driven, responsive websites that surface Dataverse data to external or internal users with fine-grained security controls based on web roles.

| Attribute         | Details                                                                                                                                                                 |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Typical Scenarios | Customer self-service portals, knowledge bases, partner portals, event registration sites                                                                               |
| User Types        | Authenticated (login required) or anonymous (public access)                                                                                                             |
| Security          | Web roles control page and data access for registered users                                                                                                             |
| Licensing         | Per-site capacity covering a monthly quota of login sessions or page views; additional capacity purchasable. Internal users may also need Power Apps/Automate licensing |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Power Pages when users outside the organization need authenticated or anonymous access to business data through a branded website. Avoid Canvas Apps for public or customer-facing access patterns; use Power Pages so identity, web roles, site security, and external capacity licensing are handled through the appropriate portal model.

## Design Studio & Templates

Power Pages includes an intuitive Design Studio with starter templates (e.g., scheduling, customer self-service) to accelerate development. Advanced customization is available through the Portal Management app or custom HTML/CSS/JavaScript injected into pages.

| Tool                      | Purpose                                                                                   |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Design Studio             | Low-code page builder for styling, adding forms, and configuring lists                    |
| Portal Management App     | Advanced configuration of site settings, web roles, content snippets, and templates       |
| Custom Code (HTML/CSS/JS) | Full control for complex UI or interaction requirements beyond low-code options           |
| Licensing                 | Creators and administrators need a Power Pages license or a qualifying Power Apps license |

## Microsoft Copilot Studio

Microsoft Copilot Studio is a platform for creating and orchestrating AI-driven conversational agents (copilots) that leverage large language models. It enables organizations to build domain-specific AI assistants that can both converse with users and take meaningful actions through integrated tools and connectors.

### AI Orchestration Platform

Copilot Studio provides a low-code interface to design multi-turn conversation flows, define system prompts for AI agents, and integrate with plugins and tools — enabling it to fetch enterprise data and perform transactions without heavy custom development.

| Capability             | Description                                                                                                                                                  |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Conversation Design    | Visual canvas for building multi-turn dialog flows with branching logic and fallback handling                                                                |
| LLM Integration        | Powered by large language models for natural language understanding and generation                                                                           |
| Tool/Plugin Actions    | Connects to Dataverse, Power Automate flows, external APIs to take actions or retrieve data                                                                  |
| Computer Use           | Allows agents to operate websites and desktop applications through visual perception, reasoning, mouse actions, and keyboard input when APIs are unavailable |
| Licensing (as of 2026) | Premium capability; requires Microsoft 365 Copilot or acquisition of Copilot Credits                                                                         |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Copilot Studio when the desired experience is conversational, requires multi-turn reasoning, or must combine knowledge retrieval with tool-based actions. Avoid selecting Copilot Studio only because a requirement mentions AI; if the need is document extraction, prediction, or classification inside an app or flow, AI Builder may be the simpler fit.

## Agent Flows

Agent flows are the automation experience in Copilot Studio for building deterministic, rule-based workflows that can be triggered by users, schedules, events, or agents. They complement autonomous agent reasoning by executing predefined process steps consistently, such as retrieving records, sending notifications, requesting approvals, calling connectors, running prompts, processing documents, or returning a structured response to the calling agent.

| Attribute        | Details                                                                                                                                  |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best For         | AI-first automation steps that must run predictably inside or alongside a Copilot Studio agent                                           |
| Trigger Patterns | Instant, scheduled, event-based, or triggered by an agent during a conversation or autonomous process                                    |
| Action Types     | AI actions, prompts, document processing, human approvals, control logic, data operations, connectors, and child flows                   |
| Licensing        | Consumes Copilot Studio capacity / Copilot Credits; AI tools and AI Builder capabilities used inside agent flows consume Copilot Credits |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Agent Flows when an agent must execute predictable automation steps, combine AI actions with deterministic business logic, request human review, or orchestrate connector-based actions within the Copilot Studio environment. Avoid Agent Flows for broad enterprise background automation that does not require agent context; use Power Automate Cloud Flows instead when the process is primarily system-to-system automation outside an agent experience.

## Computer Use

Computer Use is a Copilot Studio tool that lets an agent interact with websites and desktop applications through a graphical user interface by using visual perception, reasoning, virtual mouse clicks, and keyboard input. It is intended for scenarios where no reliable API, connector, or direct system integration is available, allowing the agent to operate applications in a way similar to a human user.

| Attribute       | Details                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Best For        | Agent-driven UI automation for websites or desktop applications that lack APIs or connectors                                                                                    |
| Execution Model | Computer-using agent model observes the screen, reasons over the current state, and acts through virtual mouse and keyboard input                                               |
| Typical Uses    | Legacy application automation, web form completion, data entry, invoice processing, data extraction, and exception handling where UI interaction is required.                   |
| Governance      | Requires environment-level governance, security review, credential handling, monitoring, run history, and human-in-the-loop checkpoints for sensitive or low-confidence actions |
| Licensing       | Uses Copilot Studio capacity / Copilot Credits; validate model tier, hosted browser, environment, and tenant settings before rollout                                            |

**Selection guidance:** Choose Computer Use when an agent must complete tasks in a website or desktop application and no stable API, connector, or direct integration exists. Avoid Computer Use when a reliable API, connector, custom connector, Agent Flow, Cloud Flow, or traditional integration pattern can meet the requirement, because UI automation introduces operational, security, and oversight risk even when it is AI-assisted.

Plugins (Tools) Integration

Copilot Studio uses a plugin architecture compatible with the OpenAI plugin model, enabling agents to connect to data and actions. Microsoft provides out-of-the-box connectors for Dataverse, Power Automate, web search, and more, with support for custom connectors.

| Plugin Type           | Description                                                                    | Licensing                                      |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Dataverse Connector   | Ground the agent in enterprise structured data stored in Dataverse             | Dataverse license required for the environment |
| Power Automate Plugin | Trigger flows from within a copilot conversation to perform multi-step actions | Power Automate license as applicable           |
| Web Search            | Enable the agent to retrieve current information from the public internet      | Included in Copilot Studio platform            |
| Custom Connectors     | Build bespoke plugins targeting proprietary APIs or third-party services       | Follows standard/premium connector licensing   |

Responsible AI Controls

Copilot Studio incorporates features designed to ensure responsible and safe AI usage, including content moderation, user feedback loops, and controls aligned with Microsoft's Responsible AI principles. Organizations should evaluate these controls as part of their governance strategy before deploying copilots to end users.

- Content moderation to filter inappropriate or harmful outputs
- User feedback mechanisms for continuous quality improvement
- Adherence to Microsoft's Responsible AI principles (fairness, reliability, privacy, inclusiveness, transparency, accountability)
- No separate license for Responsible AI controls — covered under standard compliance and usage terms

## Connectors & AI Builder

Connectors and AI Builder are cross-cutting capabilities that span multiple Power Platform components. They are not standalone products but are essential considerations in solution design, affecting both functionality and licensing.

### Connectors

Connectors are pre-built integrations to external services available to Power Apps and Power Automate. As of 2026, over 900 connectors are available, spanning Microsoft services, popular SaaS applications, and on-premises systems.

| Category            | Examples                                                                           | Licensing                                                                  |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Standard Connectors | SharePoint, OneDrive, Outlook, Teams, Excel Online, MSN Weather                    | Available on Microsoft 365 and basic Power Platform licenses               |
| Premium Connectors  | SQL Server, Salesforce, SAP, Dataverse (from flows), ServiceNow, Adobe Sign        | Require Power Apps or Power Automate Premium license                       |
| Custom Connectors   | Organization-built connectors targeting proprietary or niche APIs                  | Requires Premium license; follows OpenAPI / Azure API Management standards |
| On-Premises Gateway | Bridge for connecting cloud flows and apps to on-premises SQL, SharePoint, etc.    | Gateway software free; data source licenses apply                          |
| DLP Governance      | Data Loss Prevention policies govern which connectors can interact with each other | No additional license; managed through Power Platform Admin Center         |

### AI Builder

AI Builder provides turnkey AI capabilities that can be integrated directly into Power Apps and Power Automate. It supports both prebuilt models — ready to use without training — and custom models trained on organization-specific data.

| Model Type      | Examples                                                                                           | Licensing                                       |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Prebuilt Models | Invoice processing, receipt scanning, sentiment analysis, business card reader, ID document reader | Copilot Credits; credits consumed per operation |
| Custom Models   | Prediction (binary/multi-class), object detection, form processing on custom documents             | Copilot Credits; credits consumed per operation |
| Licensing       | AI Builder uses Copilot Credits there are licensed separately as an add-on                         |                                                 |

**Selection guidance:** Choose AI Builder for embedded AI tasks such as document processing, receipt extraction, prediction, classification, and sentiment analysis within Power Apps or Power Automate. Avoid AI Builder when the requirement is open-ended conversational assistance, multi-turn reasoning, enterprise knowledge Q&A, or autonomous tool orchestration.

## Licensing Summary

The following table provides a consolidated overview of licensing requirements across all Power Platform components. Always validate against current Microsoft licensing documentation, as licensing terms may be updated.

| Component                             | Minimum License Required                        | Key Notes                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Power Apps – Canvas                   | Microsoft 365 (standard connectors)             | Premium license needed for Dataverse or premium connectors                                                |
| Power Apps – Model-Driven             | Power Apps Premium                              | Requires Dataverse; premium license mandatory                                                             |
| Power Apps – Code Apps                | Power Apps Premium                              | Validate Dataverse, connector, environment, and service dependencies before rollout                       |
| Power Automate – Cloud Flows          | Microsoft 365 (standard connectors)             | Premium connectors require Power Automate Premium plan                                                    |
| Power Automate – Desktop (Attended)   | Per-user RPA license                            | User must be present during execution                                                                     |
| Power Automate – Desktop (Unattended) | Unattended RPA add-on                           | Per-bot, per-machine concurrency model                                                                    |
| Dataverse                             | Power Apps / Power Automate Premium             | Limited version included with M365 (Dataverse for Teams)                                                  |
| Power Pages                           | Per-site capacity license                       | Additional capacity purchasable; internal users may need Power Apps license                               |
| Copilot Studio                        | Microsoft 365 Copilot or Copilot Credits        | Premium capability; often bundled with Dynamics 365 / Power Platform plans                                |
| Copilot Studio – Agent Flows          | Copilot Studio capacity / Copilot Credits       | AI tools, prompts, AI Builder models, and actions executed in agent flows consume Copilot Credits         |
| Copilot Studio – Computer Use         | Copilot Studio capacity / Copilot Credits       | Validate model tier, hosted browser, security, credential, and environment settings before production use |
| AI Builder                            | Copilot Credits                                 |                                                                                                           |
| Premium Connectors                    | Power Apps and Power Automate Premium licensing | Standard connectors available on basic / M365 licenses                                                    |

## Common Selection Trade-offs

| Decision                        | Prefer                                                                                 | When                                                                                                                                      | Watch Out For                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Canvas Apps vs. Code Apps       | Canvas Apps for rapid business delivery;<br>Code Apps for advanced engineering control | The main driver is either maker-led productivity or professional development flexibility.                                                 | Canvas Apps can become hard to maintain if requirements exceed low-code abstractions.                                          |
| Model-Driven Apps vs. Code Apps | Model-Driven Apps for Dataverse process consistency; Code Apps for bespoke UX          | The choice is between generated process UI and custom software experience.                                                                | Code Apps increase development, testing, and support ownership.                                                                |
| Cloud Flows vs. Agent Flows     | Cloud Flows for general automation;<br>Agent Flows for agent-coupled automation        | The decision depends on whether the workflow belongs to a broader process or to a Copilot Studio agent experience.                        | Agent Flows consume Copilot Studio capacity and should not replace Power Automate for unrelated background automation.         |
| Desktop Flows vs. Computer Use  | Desktop Flows for deterministic RPA;<br>Computer Use for agent-driven UI interaction   | The decision depends on whether the UI automation should be scripted and repeatable or reasoned through by an agent using visual context. | Computer Use can adapt to UI changes but requires stronger governance, credential controls, human oversight, and auditability. |

## Architectural Guidance

When selecting components for a solution, apply the following decision principles to ensure the right tool is chosen for each scenario. These guidelines complement the detailed component descriptions above.

### Interface Selection

- Use Canvas Apps for internal users requiring highly customized or multi-source interfaces.
- Use Model-Driven Apps for process-centric internal solutions built on structured Dataverse data.
- Use Code Apps when a fully bespoke web experience, advanced frontend framework, or professional software engineering model is required.
- Use Power Pages for external-facing web interfaces (customers, partners, public) — not Canvas Apps.

### Automation Selection

**Copilot Studio automation note:** Agent Flows should be considered when automation is part of an agent experience, especially when the workflow needs AI actions, prompts, human review, or structured execution initiated by a copilot.

- Use Cloud Flows for cloud-based integrations, event-driven triggers, and API orchestration.
- Use Desktop Flows (RPA) only when legacy systems lack APIs and UI automation is the only option.

- Factor in unattended RPA add-on costs when automating without user presence (e.g., overnight batch jobs).
- Use Agent Flows when the automation is initiated by, embedded in, or tightly coupled to a Copilot Studio agent and should consume Copilot Studio capacity.
- Use Computer Use when a Copilot Studio agent must operate a website or desktop application through the UI because no reliable API, connector, or flow-based integration exists.

## Data Platform Selection

- Use Dataverse as the default data store for enterprise-grade solutions requiring security, relationships, and business logic.
- Use virtual tables when external data must appear in Dataverse without duplication.
- Use dataflows for scheduled bulk ETL into Dataverse from external sources.

## AI & Copilot Selection

- Use AI Builder for embedded, form-based AI (OCR, prediction) within apps and flows.
- Use Copilot Studio for conversational AI agents that need to answer questions and take actions.
- Use Agent Flows for deterministic AI-enabled workflows inside Copilot Studio, such as document processing, prompt execution, approvals, connector actions, and structured responses back to an agent.
- Use Computer Use for agentic UI automation where the agent must visually interpret and interact with an application; require explicit guardrails, approved systems, credential controls, and audit review.
- Evaluate Responsible AI controls and organizational governance policies before deploying any AI-powered copilot.

## Licensing Upfront Planning

- Identify all premium connectors, Dataverse dependencies, and RPA requirements at design time.
- Engage licensing and procurement teams early — premium plans significantly affect project budgets.
- Monitor Power Platform request limits to avoid throttling in high-volume automation scenarios.

## Decision Method

### Scenario-Based Selection Examples

- **Enterprise employee experience portal:** Use a Code App when the solution needs a highly customized web experience built with React, Vue, or another modern framework while still consuming Dataverse, connectors, Power Automate flows, and platform-managed authentication.
  - **Legacy vendor portal automation:** Use Computer Use when an agent must log into a vendor portal, read on-screen information, complete forms, or extract data and no API or connector is available. Add human approval checkpoints for submissions, financial actions, or sensitive data changes.
- **Define the audience:** internal users, external authenticated users, anonymous users, makers, administrators, or AI agents.
- **Define the interaction model:** custom app interface, structured business application, external portal, background workflow, RPA automation, embedded AI, or conversational agent.
- **Define the data pattern:** simple list data, relational enterprise data, external system of record, real-time virtualized data, copied analytical data, or document-based data.



- **Define the automation pattern:** event-driven, scheduled, instant, human-in-the-loop, attended RPA, unattended RPA, or agent-triggered action.
- **Validate cross-cutting constraints before final selection:** licensing, security, DLP, ALM, monitoring, performance, support ownership, and responsible AI requirements.
- **Evaluate pro-code fit:** if the solution requires a fully bespoke UX, advanced frontend frameworks, or software engineering control beyond low-code capabilities, evaluate Code Apps before forcing the requirement into Canvas or Model-Driven Apps.
- **Evaluate UI automation fit:** if a task requires interacting with a web or desktop interface and no API or connector exists, compare Desktop Flows and Computer Use; prefer the option that offers the right balance of determinism, adaptability, governance, and operational support.
- **Licensing note:** Licensing statements in this document should be treated as design-time indicators, not final commercial guidance. Licensing can change and must be validated against the current Microsoft Power Platform licensing documentation before procurement, deployment, or production rollout.

---

*This document is intended for internal architectural reference. Verify all licensing details against current Microsoft documentation.*